

Sensory Diet Directory: Home & Classroom Heavy Work Activities

35 Proprioceptive & Deep Pressure Exercises to Regulate Nervous System | Framework: Ayres Sensory Integration (ASI) Therapy

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Clinical Resource Packet

CHILD'S NAME	AGE / GRADE	DATE	COMPLETED BY

Heavy Work Activities (Proprioceptive Calming & Grounding)		
CATEGORY	ACTIVITIES TO DO AT HOME / SCHOOL	SENSORY PURPOSE
Pushing & Pulling	• Wall push-ups (push against wall with flat hands for 10 seconds) • Carrying loaded laundry basket across hallway • Pulling a wagon loaded with books or toys • Vacuuming living room rug	Sends calming deep-muscle input to brainstem to down-regulate agitation.
Lifting & Carrying	• Carrying grocery bags into kitchen • Wearing a weighted backpack (max 10% body weight) on school walk • Stack heavy floor cushions into a tower	Stabilizes vestibular system and improves body boundary awareness.
Crashing & Jumping	• Jumping 20 times on mini-trampoline with rhythmic counting • Crashing into a mountain of pillows or beanbag chairs • Bear walks and crab walks across living room floor	Safely discharges high motor energy for sensory-seeking children.
Oral Motor Calming	• Drinking thick smoothie through a thin straw (strong suction) • Chewing crunchy raw carrots, celery, or pretzel sticks • Blowing bubbles or pinwheels with long steady exhalations	Oral suction activates the vagal calming reflex and slows heart rate.

Sensory Diet Tip: Schedule heavy-work activities 15 minutes BEFORE known high-stress transitions (e.g. before sitting down for homework or leaving the house).